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Choosing an Operation

Most word problems require you to choose an operation or a combination of operations. How do you know which operation to pick? Good test takers watch for words and phrases that suggest a certain operation.

Addition	Subtraction	Multiplication	Division
sum	difference	product	quotient
total	minus	times	divided
plus	how many more	doubled	shared equally
in all	how many less	per	equal parts
combined	how much left	each	each
altogether			

These word clues are only a guide. Addition and subtraction are opposite operations, so you will sometimes see addition words in a subtraction problem. The same is true for multiplication and division. As you read, you should also pay attention to any numbers that are missing from the problem.

Example

Hide

A lamp is placed on a table. The combined height of the lamp and the table is 54 inches. The table is 36 inches tall. What operation should you use to find the height of the lamp?

Step 1
Look for words that suggest a certain operation.
Combined is an addition word. The height of the lamp plus the height of the table is the combined height.

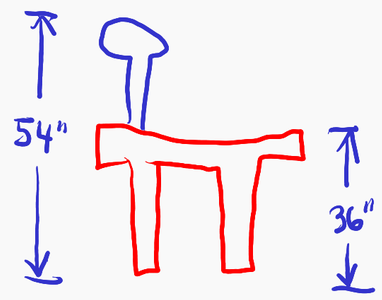
Step 2
What information is missing?

Lamp height + Table height = Combined height

? 36 54

$h + 36 = 54$

You don't know the height of the lamp.



$h = 54 - 36$
$= 18"$

Step 3
Choose an operation.
Since you already know the combined height, addition doesn't make sense. You should choose the opposite operation: subtraction.

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